Ava Q. Ma de Sousa
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EDUCATION & TRAINING

Ph.D. in Psychological and Brain Sciences **2027 *(Expected)***
Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences Emphasis *Santa Barbara, USA*
University of California, Santa Barbara
Advisor: Dr. Hongbo Yu

Research M.Sc. in Brain and Cognitive Sciences (*cum laude*) **2021**
University of Amsterdam *Amsterdam, Netherlands*
Advisors: Dr. David Amodio & Dr. Jan Engelmann

B.Sc. in Cognitive Sciences & Psychology (high distinction) **2019**
University of Toronto *Toronto, Canada*
Honor's Thesis Advisor: Dr. Gillian Einstein

HONORS & AWARDS

P.E.O. AnnaBelle B. Bush Memorial Scholar (25,000 USD)	2026-2027
Social Sciences & Humanities Research Council Fellowship (120,000 CAD)	2022-2026
UCSB Graduate Division Dissertation Fellowship (10,800 USD)	2026
UCSB Humanities and Social Sciences Research Grant (3000 USD)	2026
Charles McClintock Award for Research & Service	2026
International Society for Research on Emotion Travel Grant (1,000 USD)	2026
Academic Senate Doctoral Student Travel Grant (Domestic) (900 USD)	2026
SPSP Graduate Registration Stipend	2026
UCSB Graduate Student Association Travel Grant	2025
SANS Diversity Travel Award (500 USD)	2025
International Doctoral Recruitment Fellowship, UCSB	2021
Early Career Fund Grant, Master Brain & Cognitive Sciences (70 EUR)	2021
Mind and Brain Award, Master Brain & Cognitive Sciences (200 EUR)	2020
Anna And Alex Beverly Memorial Fellowship (2,000 CAD)	2019-2020
Arts & Science Student Union Travel Grant (200 CAD)	2019
Dean's List Scholar at the University of Toronto	2016-2019
Louis Savlov Scholarship In Sciences And Humanities (300 CAD)	2017
University of Toronto Scholar's Award (6,000 CAD)	2015
Warren Goldring Residence Scholarship (1,100 CAD)	2015

PUBLICATIONS IN PREP AND UNDER REVIEW (* indicates trainee)

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Thapar, S.*, Chen, A. X., Zhao, S. W., Qin, T.*, Clark, P. S., Earp, B. D. Yu, H. (*Under review*). Historical Dynamics and Cultural Associations of Relational Norms in American and Chinese Political Discourse. https://doi.org/10.21203/rs.3.rs-11342307/v1

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Tellefsen S.*, McCray I., Howard S. (*Under review*). When Injustice Mobilizes or Demobilizes: The Conditional Effects of Vicarious Racism on Collective Action Across Racial Groups.

Doriscar, J., **Ma de Sousa A. Q.,** Hoard, L., Perry, S. Gardner, W., Brady, W. (Pre-print). Invisible Wounds: Superhumanization of Black Victims is Associated with Less Moral Outrage in Response to Racial Injustice. https://osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/m3g4j_v1

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (*In prep*). Self-Model Reliability and Neural Correlates of Social Prediction.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Earp, B. D., Pruessner, L., Clark, M.S., Koopman-Holm, B., Yu, H. (*In prep*). How cultural and relational norms underlie social emotion generation.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Okhan, M., Molinaro, A.*, Sznycer, D., Yu, H. (*In prep*). Neural Representations of Criminal Severity Across 4,000 Years of Legal History.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Koopman-Holm, B. D., Yu, H. (*In prep*). Negative affect avoidance and its role in political (in)action.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Howard S., Tellefsen S., **Ma de Sousa A. Q.**, McCray I. (2026). The Relationship Between Black Americans' Recent and Lifetime Exposure to Vicarious Racism and Past and Future Collective Action Behaviors. *Scientific Reports*. *https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-026-48864-x*

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Furtado Fernandes, L., Ford, E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2025). Loneliness is associated with unstable and distorted emotion transition predictions. *Communications Psychology*. *https://www.nature.com/articles/s44271-025-00310-w*

Alea Albada, N., Woods, V. E., German, T., & **Ma de Sousa, A. Q.** (2025). Gaining insights: Learning about introduction to psychology from former students' personal stories. In R. R. Totton & C. A. Sanderson (Eds.), *Teaching introduction to psychology*. Edward Elgar Publishing. https://doi.org/10.4337/9781035350612

Ma de Sousa, A. Q., & Yu, H. (2025). A framework for studying the conceptual structure of human relationships. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*. *https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1364661325000750*

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Chang, J., Lu, C, Li, W., Zhou, X., Yu, H. How are social emotions computed in relational contexts? Invited Long Abstract Submission. *Affective Science* (2023). https://doi.org/10.1007/s42761-023-00230-0

Chang, L. A., Armaos, K., Warns, L., **Ma de Sousa, A. Q.**, Paauwe, F., Scholz, C., & Engelmann, J. B. (2023). Mentalizing in an economic games context is associated with enhanced activation and connectivity in left temporoparietal junction. *Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience*. *https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10243902/*

Loinaz, I., Barboni-Pekmezian, L., **Ma de Sousa, A**. (2020) Gender differences in child to parent violence risk factors. *Anales de Psicología, 36* (3), 408-417. https://doi.org/10.6018/analesps.428531

Loinaz, I., **Ma de Sousa, A**. (2020). Assessing risk factors in clinical and judicial child-to-parent violence cases. *European Journal of Psychology Applied to Legal Context, 12* (1), 43-51. https://doi.org/10.6018/analesps.428531

Loinaz, I., Bigas, N., **Ma de Sousa, A**. (2019). Comparing Intra and Extra-Familial Child Abuse in a Forensic Context. *Psicothema*, *31* (3), 271-276. https://doi.org/10.7334/psicothema2018.351

SCIENTIFIC LEADERSHIP

Symposium Chair & Organizer – '*Understanding Others' Emotions: Neural Mechanisms, Structured Beliefs, and Social Context'*, *Society for Affective Science Annual Conference* (2026)
Creator & Co-Host, *Minds Matter Podcast* (May 2020-Present)
Committee Member, *Social Affective Neuroscience Society Social Media Committee* (Sept 2026 - Present)
Committee Member, *Social Affective Neuroscience Society Equity, Diversity, Inclusion, and Justice Committee* (Oct 2025 - Present)
Board Member & Co-President, *Access Grads Leadership Board* (July 2022 – July 2026)
Organizer & Founding Member, *ReproducibiliTEA UCSB Chapter* (Jan 2023 - Present)
Graduate Student Representative, *UCSB PBS Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Committee* (Dec 2022 – July 2024)
Graduate Student Representative, *UCSB PBS Admissions Committee* (2023 Admissions Cycle)
Organizer & Founding Member, *Open Science Student Group, University of Amsterdam* (Nov 2019 – Aug 2021)
President, *Cognito Board - Master Brain and Cognitive Science Student Union* (Sept 2020 - Aug 2021)
Head of PR and Communication, *Cognito Board - Master Brain and Cognitive Science Student Union* (2019-2020)

GUEST LECTURES

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Statistics*. (2026, May). Invited Guest Lecture, Lab in Social Psychology (UCSB): Prof. David Sherman.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Replication & Open Science.* (2026, March). Invited Guest Lecture, Introduction to Social Psychology Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Intergroup Relations*. (2025, May). Invited Guest Lecture, Social Neuroscience Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Replication & Open Science* (2024, October). Invited Guest Lecture, Introduction to Social Psychology Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Replication & Open Science*. (2024, April). Invited Guest Lecture, Introduction to Social Psychology Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Intergroup Relations*. (2024, February). Invited Guest Lecture, Social Neuroscience Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

INVITED TALKS

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Zhao, S., Yu, H. (2026, November). *Quantitative Text Analyses of US and Chinese Political Discourse.* Quantitative Methods in Social Sciences Seminar, UC Santa Barbara. Director: Karen Nylynd-Gibson. Santa Barbara, CA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Zhao, S., Yu, H. (2026, September). *Tracing Psychological Change through Historical Text in China and the U.S*. Cultural Evolution and Historical Psychology Talk Series; Founding Director: Johannes A. Karl. Virtual.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck M. E., Baek, E.B., Burns S. M., Yu H. (2026, July). *Neural disruptions of the self in loneliness*. Cognition and Philosophy Lab, Monash University PI: Jakob Hohwy. Melbourne, Australia.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2026, May). *Behavioral and neural patterns of predicting emotion transitions: The moderating role of loneliness*. Princeton Social Neuroscience Lab, PI: Diana Tamir. Princeton, NJ (Virtual).

Ma de Sousa A. Q. (2026, April). *What We Owe Each Other: A Computational Model of Relational Norms, Moral Judgments and Social Emotions Across Cultures.* PEO Santa Barbara Chapter Meeting. Santa Barbara, CA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2026, March). *Behavioral and neural patterns of predicting emotion transitions: The moderating role of loneliness*. Columbia Social Neuroscience Lab, PI: Meghan Meyer. New York, NY.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2026, March). *Relational emotions: from computations of social emotion across cultures, to processing distortions of loneliness*. Toronto Decision Neuroscience Lab, PI: Cendri Hutcherson. Toronto, ON.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2025, May). *Relational Emotions*. Center for Evolutionary Psychology. Santa Barbara, CA.

CONFERENCE TALKS

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Earp. B., Yu H. (2026, July). *Social Emotions in Relational Context: A Cross-Cultural Computational Approach*. International Society for Research on Emotion Conference; Brisbane, Australia.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2026, March). *The Moderating Role of Loneliness on Emotion Transition Predictions: Neural and Behavioral Evidence* in Symposium: Understanding Others' Emotions: Neural Mechanisms, Structured Beliefs, and Social Context (Chair: **Ma de Sousa, A. Q.**). Society of Affective Science Annual Conference; Pittsburgh, PA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Earp. B., Yu H. (2026, March). *A computational model predicting experiences of gratitude and pride across relationships and cultures*. Positive Emotions Preconference at Society of Affective Science Annual Conference; Pittsburgh, PA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Cui Q., Welborne, B.L., Hong, Y., Ratner, K.G. (2024, April). *Affective and motivational effects of social identity threats*. Social Affective Neuroscience Society Annual Conference, Toronto, Canada.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. Albada, N., German, T., Woods, V. (2023, October). *Bridging the Gap Between the Novice and Experienced Learner with Peer Insight Discussion Videos*. Engaging Teaching Symposium, Santa Barbara, CA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. Grisco, M., Butler, F. V., Padilla-Garcia, D., Ratner, K.G. (2023, April). *How social identity influences perceptions of and reactions to blatant racism*. Western Psychological Association Convention, Riverside, CA.

Jonušaitė, I., Kühn M., **Ma de Sousa A. Q.**, Pingouras, A., Zimmerman, M. M. L., Campdepadrós Barrios J., Carbello, D., Steijger, M. (2021, June) *Bottom-up Curriculum Change: Student Recommendations on More Effective Education about Better Research Practices,* 2021 Meeting of the Society for the Improvement of Psychological Science, Virtual.

Ma de Sousa, A. Q., *Consciousness, Emotion and the Social World*. (2021, June) Talk presented at: The Society for Philosophy and Psychology Annual Meeting, Princeton, NJ (Virtual).

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Graduate Student Researcher & Teaching Assistant, *UC Santa Barbara* 2021-Present
Introduction to Statistics (x5), Lab in Social Psychology (x3),
Introduction to Social Psychology (x3), Social Cognition,
Close Relationships, Introduction to Psychology

Graduate Student Researcher & Teaching Assistant, *UC Santa Barbara* 2024, 2025
Introduction to Social Psychology
Designed and independently taught undergraduate social psychology course;
Mean student evaluations: 4.71/5 and 4.85/5.

Teaching Assistant, *University of Amsterdam* 2020
Milestones, Promises and Pitfalls

MENTORING EXPERIENCE

RESEARCH MENTORING

Honor's thesis students

Ajoonee Sidhu (2025-Present), **Srishti Thapar** (2025-2026; URCA award), **Isaiah Lopez** (2023-2024), **Miles Anim-Appiah** (2022-2023; UC-HBCU Summer Intern), **Maggie Grisco** (2022-2023; Gene & Susan Lucas Undergraduate Research Awar, URCA award)

Research assistants

Valentina Zhu (2026-Present), **Hannah Delizo** (2026-Present), **Nara Park** (2026-Present), **Drake Zimmerman** (2024-Present), **Tianhao Qin (**2024-Present), **David Dai** (2024-Present), **Hongyu Luo** (2023-2024), **Alexa Molinaro** (2023-2024), **Jazmin Vazquez** (FRAP Award Winner, 2023-2024), **Julie Acevesamezola** (2023-2024), **Sydney Scott** (2022-2024; FRAP Award), **Shannon Twomey** (2023-2024), **Hannah Yoon** (2022-2023), **Irena Wong** (2021-2023, FRAP Award), **Joseph Chang** (2021-2022; FRAP award), **Jimi Tyszka** (2021-2022; FRAP award), **Robert Hinojos** (2021-2022; FRAP award), **Jimi Tyszka** (2021-2022; FRAP)

MENTORSHIP PROGRAM MENTORING

Undergraduate students (Access Grads Mentorship Program)

Melina Zachou (2025-2026), **Jayme Daijo** (2025-2026), **Emily Nartker** (2025-2026), **Jules Oliver** (2024-2026), **Anna-Sofia Guerra** (2022-2025), **Meghety Mikhaelian** (2024-2025), **Gabriela Palafox** (2024-2025), **Xitlali Velazquez** (2024-2025), **Kangning Yu** (2023-2024), **Luisa Fernanda Escamilla** (2022-2023), **Kim Tran** (2022-2023)

Graduate students

Zhaoquan (Harold) Wang (Teaching Assistant Advisory Program mentee, 2026-Present)
Tara Sarkar (Teaching Assistant Advisory Program mentee, 2025-2026)
Celine Tsoi (Psychological and Brain Sciences Program mentee, 2024-Present)

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

International Society for Research on Emotion	2022-Present
European Society for Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience	2025-Present
Social Affective Neuroscience Society	2022-Present
Society for Affective Science	2021-Present
Society for Personality and Social Psychology	2020-Present
International Society for Self and Social Identity	2022-2023